THE BIG REVELATIONS

RTI applications have exposed significant controversies across sectors, reshaping transparency and accountability in India

» 2G spectrum scam RTI disclosures highlighted irregularities in the allocation of 2G spectrum licences in 2008, unveiling a major corruption scandal involving undue favours, resulting in huge losses to the exchequer

» Coal allocation scam RTI inquiries exposed irregularities in coal block allocations (2004-09), revealing favouritism and non-transparent processes

» CWG scam RTI revealed large-scale corruption in the organisation of the 2010 Commonwealth Games in Delhi, including inflated costs and embezzlement

» Farmer suicides A 2019 RTI response highlighted the alarming rate of farmer suicides—15,000 deaths in Maharashtra alone—which pointed to a widespread agrarian crisis in India

» Electoral bonds Several RTI applications revealed opacity in the electoral bonds scheme, raising concerns about anonymous political donations

» Demonetisation As per an RTI response, the RBI did not agree with the Centre's claim that demonetisation would curb black money



"The enactment of RTI is the first single piece of legislation to ensure transparency and delivery by the government. Each citizen can now by law put questions and expect answers from the government"

— SONIA GANDHI, *then Congress president at a rally in 2010*



guest column

The Act Needs Muscle

FROM THE ARCHIVES
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Guest Column
The Act Needs Muscle

There are no logical arguments against the need for a strong Right to Information Act. No political party or bureaucracy can publicly deny the value of access to information for fighting corruption.

–Aruna Roy

dinary Indians to hold the bureaucrats and politicians accountable.

The impact has been nothing short of transformative. It has exposed several high-profile scams, shining a light on corruption at the highest levels. For instance, the 2G spectrum scam showcased the arbitrary allocation of telecom licences, costing the exchequer an estimated Rs 1.76 lakh crore. The coal allocation scam (known as Coalgate) laid bare irregularities in coal block allotments, involving political and corporate heavyweights. RTI applications also unearthed the Adarsh Housing Society scam, where apartments meant for war widows were illegally allocated to bureaucrats and politicians in Mumbai.

At the grassroots, the RTI Act has become a tool of empowerment. Dalit students have used it to challenge biased admission practices, while rural communities have scrutinised public distribution systems to expose pilferage of ration supplies. Farmers have accessed land records to fight encroachments and demand fair compensation. The Act's penalty provisions have deterred bureaucratic delays, thus fostering accountability.

However, this beacon of transparency faces existential threats. Successive governments, wary of its disruptive potential, have sought to dilute its provisions. Amendments introduced in 2019 undermined the autonomy of Information Commissions by placing their salaries and tenures under government control. More recently, the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, exempted "personal information" from disclosure, a move critics argue will blunt the RTI's edge in combating corruption.

In a nation where millions of RTI queries are filed annually, its journey has not been without bloodshed; over 100 RTI activists have been killed, their courage met with violent reprisal. Yet, the RTI remains a symbol of participatory democracy. Its legacy lies not just in its legal framework but in the grassroots movement that birthed it—a testament to the power of collective action. As it enters its third decade, the RTI Act stands as both a triumph and a challenge: a tool for democratic accountability and a barometer of the state's commitment to transparency. ■